

Reinventing identity in the digital space: the social effect of quarantine

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In the age of information our problems have changed. When explosive reaction defeated many challenges of the 20th century, like with the fall of the wall in Berlin, this century has brought forth a deeper layer of limits to our wellbeing. Slow violence emerged as a central issue to many recurring challenges and plays with our limited attention spawn exacerbated by increasingly fast media consumption to steadily root itself everywhere we are not looking. As traditional media prioritize immediate and explosive news coverage to capitalize on sensationalism, I wish to explore how literature and narrative strategies combat the collective amnesia empowering slow violence. More particularly, I will examine this issue by tackling a long-term issue for which the crisis/solution binary is not applicable: isolation during global pandemics. Hence, the central questioning of this paper is as follows: how can we properly address the digitalization of spaces during the Covid-19 pandemic in Latin American and the consequent changes in social interactions? This topic stems from the observations made throughout the chapters of *Virtual Identities and Digital Culture* edited by Kamnen and Langille. In it, they alert on the severity of this issue: “while depression, anxiety, and burnout were already evident in the identity of a university student, the pandemic both escalated these issues and created new challenges such as adjusting to online learning and social isolation” (Lauricella, 2023). I will first go over the intersectionality of this issue with the region at large, before dissecting the concept of digital identity, and finally I will address the digital world as an escape from a harsher reality.

In a 2021 survey of undergraduate students, all respondents reported being negatively affected by the pandemic in some manner, and 59% reported high levels of psychological impact (Browning et al., 2021). The non-physical

repercussions of the pandemic are harder to identify and thus to study, and most of the research done in that field pertained to easily identifiable groups for which quarantine had a drastic impact: students. Nevertheless, as Brooks shows, a pandemic will increase stressors such as infection fears, frustration, boredom, inadequate information and financial loss (Brooks et al, 2020), which has an impact on everyone dealing with insecurity of some form on a daily basis. Therefore, this concept very much applies to most of the Latin American population too. The Brazilian movie *Nuvem Rosa* (“Pink cloud”) demonstrates how a digitalized world has wildly different repercussions on the individual level, with characters reacting very differently to their perpetual quarantine, but also on the regional level, as the different occupations of space create drastically different situations (the main character’s niece is stuck with her friend’s father, who ends up impregnating her other friends, while another of her friends is stuck alone and the movie hints at her taking her own life). Most importantly, the director Luli Gerbase uncovers a central element of the impacts of isolation in this movie: when the digital world fuels delusion or denial of the real world, exemplified by the role of the VR headset as the cathartic element sealing the main character’s fate. Hence, we ought to take the digital world as a serious issue, but also as a potential solution, to pandemics.

Portuguese is the fifth most spoken language on the internet. A large majority of this representation comes from Brazilian users having a large presence on social media and video games, even before the Covid-19 pandemic. Although the difference that peculiar time created was putting this escape at the center of Brazilian’s lives, allowing them to recreate their identities in the digital world (Euteneuer, 2023). For many, socializing took effect through multiplayer hubs that allowed physically remote individuals to hang out and interact with each other, creating even stronger and more intimate social bonds, De Koven argues (2020). These games were an opportunity for many to start anew: “the player has agency in creating their avatar, which allows them to explore new identities whether it’s an idealized version of themselves, or an identity that oscillates between the online and offline self” (Hugelmann, 2023). Interestingly, the digital interface itself plays a role in that: when creating an online persona, having a cursor allowing to adjust your gender and sexuality instead of ticking a binary “man” or “women” box already exposes the user to self-reflection. Indeed, playing around with what we aspire to be in a space where anything can be redone and with little consequence is a formatting experience that has introspective benefits (Euteneuer, 2023). Finding inner growth through games helps not

only to be at peace with oneself but also realize the intersectionality of identity as a fluid phenomenon. The different connections made by exposing these identities call the person's attention to the intersectionality of identity and therefore expose them to previously unseen or unspoken experiences.

While this may bring together communities, some other social consequences of the digitalization during pandemic took them apart. That is the case for activism, which in 2020 turned to social media as its Black Lives Matter campaign reached 24 billion total views. However, this impressive outreach does not translate in its impact: Puplamu argues the culture of "clicktivism" emerged as loud by short lived form of activism (Puplamu, 2023). As people gain moral confidence by only reposting urgent news or calls to attention, some might even argue the effects are largely negative, calling this effect "slacktivism". Little accountability emerges from these online platforms, and the escape from reality is so great some might perpetually fall in it.

In the novel *Dengue Boy* by Nieva Michel, the post-apocalyptic world is in constant uproar, with major catastrophes and events being brushed over at a fast pace leaving little time for the reader to breathe. Paradoxically, the parts that are more digestible are those where characters act as avatars in a fully immersive video game called *Christians versus Indians 2*. The action scenes are still bloody, but its predictable outcome contrasts with the rest of the novel in a paradoxical soothing way. This feeling conveyed by the author, representing the constant chaos of Latin America during the pandemic, shows how important escaping from it has been. The video game industry grew rapidly during covid with investments from all over, showcasing the medium as one of the few that still brought people together. Aware of the issues related to escaping reality, developers have started constructing their interface to tackle these issues. As Hugelmann points out in his chapter *Interface and Their Affordances*, "critical game designs aim to position game designers as individuals who imbue aspects of life into digital games, not only from a narrative standpoint, but also through mechanics and rules (Hugelmann, 2023). Emerging from quarantine, the progression back to in-person interaction deserves some attention. The break from online games and the new types of human relationships they created surely shaped new endeavors: has it made people generally more inclusive of identity as a fluid concept, or did permanently isolate individuals in tinted digital bubbles?

To conclude, in the context of pandemics, the digital world was perceived as an escape from isolated reality. Especially in Latin America where the intersectionality of socio-economic insecurities led to identity crisis, the already predominant digital world grew even further. The layout of the digital landscape renewed social interactions and led to self-exploration, contrasting with the fast-paced real world. Additionally, as many fringes of society had to relocate to that space, some were more successful than others (activism backlash). If the isolationist and psychologically detrimental impact of quarantine cannot be understated, the digital world also opened up new perspectives for many and shaped a new type of human interaction through its interface.